

Frisée (Curly Endive)

CULTIVARS

- Rhodos
- Très Fine

INTENSIVE SPACING

- 4 rows (8" - 20 cm) per bed spaced every 6" (15 cm) on the row

FERTILIZATION

- Frisées will do great in beds that were previously amended with compost and fertilized with a mix of alfalfa meal (2-0-2) and pelleted chicken manure (5-3-2).

IRRIGATION

Irrigation Type

- Drip tape (4 per bed) or sprinkler

Irrigation Management

- Root depth: Shallow (6"-24")
- General: Water consistently to avoid bitter taste. Critical to water before head development.

IMPLANTATION

We plant frisée every 4 weeks and plan to have up to 3 cuts per seeding. For each seeding, we plant enough beds for an estimated 3 weeks of harvest per planting.

Some frisée will be sold as heads, but most of it goes into our signature mesclun mix. Loose leaves of frisée make up +/- 10% of our mix. The number of beds we grow is therefore proportional to our weekly mesclun harvest targets.

In our planting program, frisée is grouped with green onions, sucre, mini-fennel and lettuce, all crops that have similar plant requirements and that are planted every 2 weeks. Frisées will be planted with those every other cycle.

EQUIPMENT

- Rotary harrow
- 30" bed prep rake
- Popping tray and marking roller

ITINERARY

- Remove tarp and clean out large debris. Use the rake if needed. *
- Uniformly apply amendments and pass with the rotary harrow at a depth of 2" (5 cm). To make transplanting easier (seeing as the soil is loose after being harrowed), we only prepare the beds when we are about to transplant.
- Pass with the dibbler-roller to mark the planting holes and bring out the well-watered trays.
- Once the beds are ready, 1 person will drop the seedlings while 2 others transplant as fast as possible. Frisée transplants are very hardy and don't need special care. 3 people/100'bed is a good ratio for efficient workflow.
- Install irrigation and water until the soil is deeply moistened.

* If the previous crop is too well established, or if the bed is too messy, mow the crop as low as possible and harrow at a depth of 2" (5 cm). Add 1" (2.5 cm) of compost evenly spread on the whole width of the bed and transplant into compost following a no-till strategy.

WEEDING

- Frisée is cultivated using the flex tine weeder 10 to 12 days after implantation, or when the weeds are at the filament/cotyledon stage. In weedy beds, a second pass should be planned 7 days later.

PLANT PROTECTION

- For really nice blanched hearts, place blanching bells on selected heads 7-10 days prior to the harvest. The bells are moved each week after the blanched hearts are harvested.

HARVEST

- Frisées are harvested in the fields in a kneeling position. Both heads and loose leaves are harvested using a VERY sharp knife. Sharpen your blades before each harvest; this will help reduce potential oxidation of the cut surface. Do not use carbon or rusted blades.
- When harvesting heads, cut high enough to remove dead and damaged outer leaves while keeping the head intact.
- When harvesting loose leaves, only take the heart of the plant (leaving the dark green outer leaves), cut just above the growing tip (for regrowth) and slice the tops off at 4" (10 cm). In the end, you want leaves that are no bigger than the palm of your hand (4" - 10 cm), with about half the leaves blanched.
- Always trim the exterior leaves after you cut, making sure the core is clean for the regrowth of the plant.

CONDITIONING

- When mixing the chicory in with the mesclun, refer to the procedures for Mesclun.
- The frisée heads are washed by quickly dunking them in a sink full of cold water.
- Use both hands (one lettuce head in each hand) to shake out any excess, and place them on a screen facing down to let them drip-dry for a moment. Make sure the frisée is in the water for no longer than a minute to avoid getting waterlogged.
- Pack the frisée tightly in storage totes, stacking them upside down to let the water drain while sitting in the cooler.

STORING

- Frisée heads are stored in cold room kept at 35 °F (2 °C) and should not stay for more than 3 days before being sold.